with an initiative to solve the refugee problem once and for all, from a position of power. Opposing them was a single minister—Defense Minister Moshe Dayan—who categorically rejected their approach and claimed that, since Israel was in a position of power, the problem it was facing was a *territorial problem and not a refugee problem*—namely, how we could preserve the new borders we had attained in this war.

Between the two camps stood Prime Minister Eshkol, who hardly uttered a word and certainly did not lead the discussion or direct it toward a decision. History has proven that Dayan's position was the one that prevailed in this debate. I leave it to the reader to decide, with the wisdom of hindsight, whether that position was the right one.

The basis for the discussion in the government was a draft document that was prepared in advance in order to assist the government in making a decision regarding the stance Israel would take in the discussion in the General Assembly, which was supposed to submit its recommendations to the Security Council. During the discussion, various numbers were waved around by some of the ministers in order to illustrate the scope of the problem. There was no consensus about the numbers, but it was generally assumed that the number of Jews in the State of Israel in 1967 was 2.3 million, and the number of Arabs in the territories under Israeli control was 1.5 million. If these figures were correct, then the demographic balance between the two populations should have worried, to say the least, the participants in the discussion.

Here are some excerpts from Dayan's remarks at these meetings:

> The refugees are not a problem that belongs to this war. They were not created in this war and they will not be resolved by the question now facing the General Assembly and the Security Council. Any attempt to tie the refugee problem to the question we want to answer now [the question of territory] will only complicate things and is not practical. We have conquered up to a certain point and they are now demanding that we withdraw to the armistice lines. This is the subject of discussion. If we say that there is a refugee issue, it will only raise the problem, and it will not relieve us of the pressure on us to withdraw. When the Egyptians were in the Gaza Strip, UNRWA controlled the refugee camps. We got the territory from Egypt; we did not get the refugee camps from UNRWA. At the General Assembly, we don't need to jump the gun and discuss the refugee problem. Our position should be that at this stage we are not publicly proposing any plans to settle the refugees. We must investigate and check, but we are not announcing plans for the settlement of refugees. If we do then we are making ourselves responsible for the problem.

Dayan proposed the following formula: